



The transition to adulthood around the Mediterranean: Contributions of the special issue



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ABSTRACT

This analysis of the papers in the special issue on the transition to adulthood around the Mediterranean calls attention to the role of the family of origin in the transition itself. All the papers analyzed a specific aspect of family relationships, focusing especially on the parent–child relationship. Moreover, several outcomes were considered, such as identity, psychological well-being, life satisfaction, and criteria of adulthood, highlighting the multidimensional features of the transitional phase young people are facing. Together, these papers make a great contribution to the current literature, especially for the ones linked to the Mediterranean area, and provide both foundation and new paths for future research.

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The study of the transition to adulthood is increasing more and more in developmental psychology. Indeed, researchers are interested in understanding how young adults feel adult themselves and are recognized by others as adults nowadays, when the absence of a predetermined path to adulthood, the uncertainty in job perspectives, the economical crisis, the changing cultural contexts, and the globalization are interacting in affecting their transition to adulthood.

The Mediterranean area has been often seen as characterized by similarities in the transition to adulthood patterns (Buchmann & Kriesi, 2011; Cordón, 1997; Iacovou, 2002; Vogel, 2002). Transitional patterns considered typical of countries in southern Europe are characterized by postponement of parental home leaving, marriage or cohabitation, and parenthood (Buchmann & Kriesi, 2011), and by their strict connection resulting in a quick sequence of marriage and parenthood, once the home leaving is completed (Buchmann & Kriesi, 2011; Lanz & Tagliabue, 2007). Moreover, the young people in this area, especially females, have difficulties in finding a stable job due to the absence of vocational training and to a strong protection of workers already employed (Buchmann & Kriesi, 2011). The existence of a southern European area has been not only affirmed in several sociological studies, but also was recently enlarged including other Mediterranean countries, such as Israel, Malta, Cyprus, and Turkey (Gal, 2010), all characterized by late industrialization, low stability or efficiency of the state, a central role of the family and religion, and a sort of “clientelistic relationships in the political arena” (Gal, 2010, p. 96). In this sense, a Mediterranean cluster of countries has been highlighted, not only generally considering the welfare of the countries, but also more specifically being linked with the transition to adulthood. Indeed, referring to the distinction proposed by Gallie and Paugam (2000) among four welfare regimes linked to social security, Walther (2009) broadened it including structures of

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education and training, structures of labour-market, and gender concerns. In doing so, four different transition regimes were found (Walther, 2006, 2009): universalistic transition regime, liberal transition regime, employment-centred transition regime, and sub-protective transition regime. The Southern European countries, such as Italy, Spain, and Portugal, were included in the sub-protective transition regime, which is characterized by “neither choice nor flexibility nor security; instead, individuals depend on the extent of family support” (p.138). There are no studies which analyze the other Mediterranean countries to see whether they can be comprised in that sub-protective transition regime, but some characteristics of the enlarged family of Mediterranean welfare states proposed by Gal (2010) could support the idea that there is a specific transitional pattern for young people living in a Mediterranean country.

Despite those similarities in general welfare, sociological features and transition pattern of Mediterranean countries, little attention has been given to the specificities of each Mediterranean country especially regarding the interacting variables in the process of the transition to adulthood. The collection of articles in this special issue addresses several features of the transition to adulthood in Mediterranean countries. Five different countries are involved: Greece, Israel, Italy, Portugal, Slovenia. Among those countries, Slovenia is the only country with a socialist history, Israel is the only not Christian country, Greece and Portugal are the countries most affected by the economic crisis, and Italy is the country in which the prolonged transition to adulthood was first observed and was studied since the end of eighties (Scabini & Donati, 1988). Thus, beside the common Mediterranean welfare, those countries also are characterized by specificities that could be interconnected to the variety of patterns in the transition to adulthood.

Across this set of articles, both features of family of origin (parent–child relationship, family climate, family resources), and individual features of young adults facing the transition to adulthood are analyzed. The studies vary in their use of qualitative, quantitative or mixed methods, and present cross-sectional or longitudinal research designs, showing how the complexity of the transition to adulthood, characterized by several micro-transitions, destandardization and a yo–yo pattern (Biggart & Walther, 2006), requires using different methodologies.

Collectively the papers in this special issue consider the transition to adulthood in different ways, elucidate the nature and relevance of family of origin in the transitional process, and investigate different young adults' outcomes. In the next four sections, the papers will be presented according to: the issues regarding the transition to adulthood investigated, the characteristics of the participants, the specific focus on the family of origin, and which transitional outcomes have been taken into account.

Issues regarding the transition to adulthood

The transition to adulthood has been investigated focusing on different issues by the authors of the papers. For instance, some of them focused on specific markers of the transition, such as leaving parental home and being committed in a stable romantic relationship (Zupančič, Komidar, & Levpušček). Other papers went into the transitional processes, such as the interconnection between the development of identity and the family of origin's features (Sestito & Sica; Oliveira, Mendonça, Coimbra, & Fontaine; Crocetti & Meeus), or into the interconnection among different kinds of close relationships (Pnevmatikos & Bardos; Lanz & Tagliabue). Finally, some papers underlined the changing processes implied in the transition, following late adolescents and young adults during their transitional years (Shulman, Vasalampi, Barr, Livne, Nurmi, & Pratt; Luengo Kanacri, Pastorelli, Zuffianò, Eisenberg, Ceravolo, & Caprara). Those differences show that, in order to capture the complexity of the transition to adulthood in the Mediterranean area, the three levels should be considered: individual level (identity, transitional markers), relational level (family of origin and other close relationships such as the romantic one), and time (the changing nature of the transitional process). However, it is very difficult to simultaneously consider all the three levels in a unique research. The present special issue provides the possibility to reflect on those three levels across the research presented.

Young people's characteristics

No uniformly accepted age range for the transition to adulthood has been defined by the scientific community, so that researchers do different choices in their studies. In the present special issue, three papers begin from the start of adolescence, longitudinally studying changes and/or predictors of the first years of the transition to adulthood (age range 12–24; Catellani et al.; Luengo Kanacri et al.; Pnevmatikos & Bardos). All the others conducted their research involving young people aged between 18 and 30.

Regarding the dichotomy between students and workers, that often is not a dichotomy because many young people both study and work, three papers considered both students and workers in their samples (Crocetti & Meeus; Oliveira et al.; Zupančič et al.). Kuhar and Reiter considered only people who are no longer in education. The other papers considered only students (Pnevmatikos & Bardos; Sestito & Sica), or considered, at the first wave, students who then became, at least some of them, workers (Castellani, Pastorelli, Eisenberg, Caffo, Forresi & Gerbino; Lanz & Tagliabue; Luengo Kanacri et al.; Shulman et al.).

Family of origin's features

The fact that, in Mediterranean countries, young people live under the same roof of their parents until late twenties/early thirties is well-known (Iacovou, 2002; Seiffge-Krenke, 2013; Vogel, 2002), and it is reported by all the papers of the special

issue, with the exception of Shulman et al.'s paper. However, recently, the prolonged co-residence with parents is characterizing also other countries (Stone, Berrington, & Falkingham, 2014), increasing the interest of the international scientific community in the role and implications of living with parents during the transition to adulthood. All the papers in this special issue examine one or more characteristics of the family, showing which are the aspects more salient in those studies. In particular, most of the papers analyze the role of parental support, both considering it as financial support, or emotional support, or support for autonomy (see contributions by Sestito & Sica; Oliveira et al.; Lanz & Tagliabue; Shulman et al.; Luengo Kanacri et al.). The prolonged co-residence with parents; the absence of financial support from the state and increased psychological uncertainty are hypothesized to be substituted by family support, especially parental support. Young adults perceive their parents as active and supportive of their autonomy (Sestito & Sica), demonstrating that parents continue to have a role in helping the transitional paths of their adult children. However, findings also show country differences. Indeed, in Italy support is not significantly linked to individual adjustment or prosocial behavior of young adults (Lanz & Tagliabue; Luengo Kanacri et al.), whereas in Portugal and Israel parental support resulted to be linked with both psychological well-being and career adaptability (Oliveira et al., Shulman et al.). Direct cross-national comparisons are not possible, however it is interesting that, in two Italian studies parental support is not significantly linked with young adults' outcomes. We may speculate that parental support is taken for granted by Italian young adults, so it constitutes a sort of secure base, but it loses its salience; another interpretation is that parental support in Italy may influence other kind of outcomes.

Beside parental support, also other constructs linked with family of origin features were analyzed. For instance, there were analyzed the positive or negative quality of the parent–child relationship, parenting, conflict, relational autonomy and connectedness, differently associated to young adults' outcomes. Researchers are aware that parent–child relationships in the transition to adulthood cannot be studied focusing only on parental support, and that they need to explore also other aspects. However, no papers considered two or more constructs together analyzing their mutual influences. Moreover, only two papers analyzed the interdependence among different family relationships (such as: marital and parent–child relationship – Lanz & Tagliabue; or parent-child and romantic relationship – Pnevmatikos & Bardos).

Outcomes of the transition to adulthood

The natural outcome of the transition to adulthood is reaching adulthood itself. However, papers presented here focused on different outcomes, revealing the importance to monitor not only the final outcome, but also the feelings, behavior, thoughts and wellbeing during the transitional process. Identity (Sestito & Sica), life satisfaction (Crogetti & Meeus; Lanz & Tagliabue; Zupančič et al.), criteria of adulthood and transitional markers (Zupančič et al.), psychological wellbeing and individual adjustment (Castellani et al.; Oliveira et al.; Lanz & Tagliabue), prosocial behavior (Luengo Kanacri et al.) and career adaptability (Shulman et al.) were all studied as linked with family of origin in the transition to adulthood. Moreover, considering the transition to adulthood a family transition, Lanz and Tagliabue also analyzed the impact of family support on parents' individual adjustment. The variety of the outcomes is due to the complexities young adults are called to face. Indeed, becoming adult does not only means feeling adult, but implies to overcome a series of challenges, maintaining own psychological well-being. The challenges involve both transitional markers (such as leaving parental home; getting married; parenthood; having a job) and individual ones (building their own identity; helping others). Moreover, the complexity of the transition to adulthood is increased by the fact that it is no longer a single transition, but a series of micro-transitions, with a yo–yo trend (Biggart & Walther, 2006).

Conclusion

This special issue originated during the XIIIth biennial conference of the European Association for Research on Adolescence on the island of Spetses, Greece, from August 29 to September 1, 2012, in which one quarter of the sessions was dedicated to the issue of the transition to adulthood, and a large number of presentations were about the transition to adulthood in one of the Southern European countries. Moreover, an invited symposium that focused on the transition to adulthood around the Mediterranean and was discussed by prof. Marion Kloep, took the attention of many colleagues who were present and actively participated to the general discussion. After this conference, a call for abstract was sent to possible authors, including many of the conference participants. From 26 submitted abstracts, the guest editors selected a shortlist of 16 abstracts with great interrater reliability. Selection was based on a set of criteria decided a priori, including aspects of content, method, results and language. Authors of selected abstracts then prepared and submitted their papers, of which 10 finally made it to this special section, after a thorough and blind review process.

The ten papers present a wide and multidimensional picture of the transition to adulthood in the Mediterranean countries. Despite the similarities regarding the welfare and the transition pattern highlighted by sociologists, the present papers show how much diversity and complexity characterize that transition. Future research directly comparing the countries of the Mediterranean area are needed, in order to understand which processes are shared by young people belonging to those countries, and which processes, instead, uniquely characterize one specific country. Findings of the present special issue and about future research can help researchers and politicians to increase the knowledge about the challenges young people have to face in their life and help them and the whole society to increase the probability to reach adulthood in the best of the possible ways. As editors, we are delighted to contribute to this by presenting this special issue in *Journal of Adolescence*.

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